THE SECOND KASHMIR WAR, 1965

Emboldened by India's 1962 setback, Pakistan planned to undertake a two-phase operation: first to foment trouble in Kashmir, and then in the second phase to bottle up the Indian Army in Kashmir by cutting off the supply line in the Chhamb–Jaurian sector of Jammu.

Operations in the Rann of Kutch

Before Pakistan's plan was put into action in Kashmir, however, the Pakistan Army undertook a limited operation in the Rann of Kutch early in 1965, ostensibly to tie down the Indian Army in the south. The Rann of Kutch is an 80km-wide and 515km-long stretch of land bordering Sindh in Pakistan and Gujarat in India. In 1965, the Indian side of the border was weakly held and guarded only by the police.

In January 1965, Pakistan began patrolling in Indian territory followed by attacks on Indian posts and took control over the ruined fort of Kanjarkot, located on the north-west fringe of the Rann of Kutch. In response, India moved its 31 Infantry Brigade Group to the Rann of Kutch, tasked with capturing Kanjarkot. Before the brigade group launched its operations, the Indian forces established the Sardar Post about 4.6km south-west of Kanjarkot to check further Pakistani incursions. Pre-empting 31 Infantry Brigade Group's attack on Kanjarkot, on 7 April 1965 Pakistan launched Operation *Desert Hawk* against forward Indian posts and overran the Sardar Post. The Indian Army responded by moving 50 (Independent) Parachute Brigade into the sector and forming HQ Kilo Sector on 17 April. The move could not, however, prevent Pakistan from launching *Desert Hawk II* and *III* to capture Indian posts at Vigokot and Biar Bet.

In response to these setbacks, India ordered general mobilization and resorted to exerting pressure on Pakistan along the Punjab border. It initiated Operation *Ablaze* in early May by putting Lieutenant General Joginder Singh Dhillon's XI Corps on alert, with HQ 15 Infantry Division concentrating at Amritsar and its units moving forward to their battle locations. The corps' 4 Mountain and 7 Infantry divisions also moved